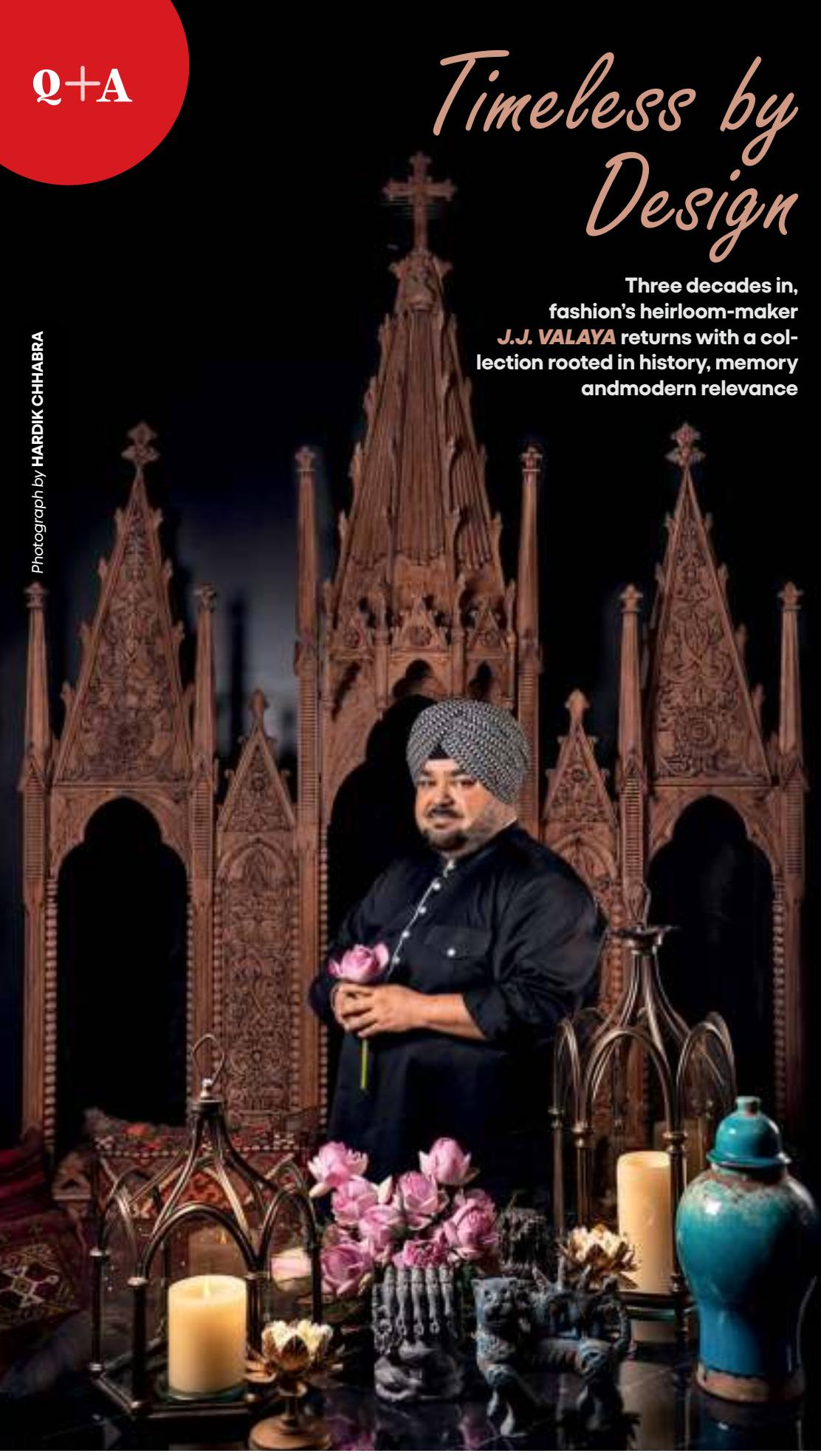
Q+A

Timeless by Design

Three decades in, fashion's heirloom-maker *J.J. VALAYA* returns with a collection rooted in history, memory andmodern relevance



Photograph by **HARDIK CHHABRA**

Q. Take us through the inspiration and creative process behind your upcoming couture collection, 'East'.

'East' draws from the romance of the 18th century, when the West viewed the East as a land of mystery and cultural depth. I explored the heritage of the Balkans, the artistry of the Far East, and India's legacy.

Q. Much of your work feels timeless yet rooted in the present. How do you maintain that balance between heritage and relevance?

True luxury isn't driven by trends, it's meant to endure. Brides often return with decades-old Valaya ensembles once worn by their mothers, asking us to simply resize or refresh them. The quality remains impeccable.

Q. You've spoken before about taking a hard reset in 2017, closing everything down. How did that moment change your creative journey?

After celebrating 25 years of the brand, I vanished just to introspect. When we returned in 2019, it was with a renewed spirit and intent.

Q. You're also known for your prowess in photography and interiors. How do these creative pursuits influence your design language?

Photography is my alter ego. I travel to photograph and, through that lens, I absorb the world—its textures, stories, smells and silences. All that gets stored somewhere within me and, eventually, it translates into my fashion mood boards. As for interiors, I've always had a keen eye for spatial aesthetics.

—with Geetika Sachdev